



The Payday Autopsy

Trace exactly what killed your last salary —
before the next one dies the same way.

12 minutes · Pen + banking app · One salary

For Nigerian earners. Works on any salary —
₦30k to ₦3m. No judgment.

Before you start

This worksheet does one thing: it tells you what happened to your last salary. Not a budget. Not a lecture. Just an honest post-mortem on one month's money.

Time it takes: About 12 minutes.

You'll need: Your phone, your banking app (all accounts), a pen.

Which month? Your last completed salary — the one that just finished, not the new one.

Ground rule: No shame. Numbers first. We're not here to call you irresponsible; we're here to find the body.

HOW TO RUN THE AUTOPSY

1. Open your banking app and go back to the day salary entered.
2. Scroll forward through every alert to the last zero balance.
3. Sort every debit into one of the seven categories that follow.
4. Add them up. Subtract from salary. What's left is your leak.

The Autopsy

Fill in what actually happened last month. Estimate if you must, but use the alert numbers wherever you can.

My last salary:

N _____

1. Charges, deductions, transfer fees

Everything that left your account before you even saw it. The money you never held.

Examples: VAT, stamp duty (N50 per transfer), account maintenance, SMS charges, PAYE, pension, NHF, bank app transfer fees, POS charges, COT.

Total for this category:

N _____

2. Family sends & 'borrow me'

Money sent to people — calls you couldn't say no to, school fees, upkeep, aunts, urgent 2k.

Examples: Parents, siblings, 'send me 5k I'll pay back', child school fees, house rent contribution, August meeting.

Total for this category:

N _____

3. Subscriptions, airtime, data & small leaks

The quiet monthly deductions you forget about. Each small, all together brutal.

Examples: Airtime, data bundle, Netflix/Showmax/Spotify, DSTv/GOTv, church/tithe, betting, MoMo/Opay wallet auto-debits.

Total for this category:

N _____

4. Loans, debts & owes

Money that went to paying back. Loan app deductions, money you owed people from last month, 'balance' you cleared.

Examples: Carbon, PalmCredit, Okash, FairMoney, Renmoney, Kuda overdraft, money you borrowed from a friend, that debt you settled.

Total for this category:

N _____

5. Generator, fuel & transit

What it cost to move and to keep the light on. Petrol, diesel, kobo-by-kobo transport.

Examples: Fuel for generator, diesel, okada/keke, Uber/Bolt, danfo, transport to work, NEPA prepaid meter top-up.

Total for this category:

N _____

6. Feeding, markets & takeaway

Food stuff in the market, eating out, quick buys when you were tired, drinks with the guys.

Examples: Market runs, Indomies, bread, soup stuff, Fast-Food (Mega Chicken/Shoprite), drinks with friends, pure water.

Total for this category:

N _____

7. The one big thing this month

Every month has one. Wedding, aso ebi, burial, travel, December clothes, child naming, a phone repair you didn't plan for.

Examples: Wedding/aso ebi, December January spending, birthday, travel (wedding/funeral), phone repair, unexpected medical.

Total for this category:

N _____

The verdict

Add up all seven category totals. Subtract from your salary. That last number is what was supposed to be buffer.

My take-home salary	N _____
Total of categories 1-7	N _____
What should have been left	N _____
What was actually left (check balance)	N _____
The leak (difference)	N _____

SUMMARY

"My salary of N _____ died on the ____ day of _____, killed primarily by _____. The second culprit was _____."

Three honest things this number tells you:

- The number is not a moral judgment. It is a structural problem — structure can be fixed; shame cannot.
- Your salary didn't disappear. It went somewhere specific, and somewhere specific can be redirected.
- The month that just finished is the same month that will repeat next month — unless you change one thing.

What to do tomorrow

You have the body. Now you have three moves before your next salary lands. Not thirty — three.

If you want the exact moves

The Paycheck-to-Paycheck Escape Plan walks you through all seven categories in order — plug, split, buffer, debt, family money, and the triage card for when a month is already on fire. 66 pages. N5,500. Written for Nigerian salaries and Nigerian life.

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